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Dear Dr. Schindler,

Thank you for the opportunity to revise our manuscript titled “Habitat coupling by small fish across lake–stream habitats: a missing link in freshwater food webs?”. We appreciate the helpful feedback from you and both reviewers and have addressed all comments in the revised manuscript and accompanying point-by-point response letter.

Our study examines how small-bodied fishes link adjacent lake and stream habitats through their seasonal resource use, movement, and biomass flux across a connected freshwater landscape. In response to concerns raised by both reviewers, we expanded the description of our statistical methods and results in the main text. We also conducted additional analyses to assess whether pooling common and golden shiner species was appropriate for our stable isotope, biomass, and body size data. Further, we clarified that the telemetry findings apply only to golden shiners because common shiners were not tagged with acoustic transmitters.

We note that our results have largely remained the same despite changes to some aspects of our modelling approaches, such as adding random effects to account for repeated sampling at the same locations, as suggested by the reviewers. These changes have strengthened the evidence we present for our overall findings regarding the role of small-bodied fish species in linking lake and stream habitats.

Lastly, we have incorporated both of your recommendations. The revised title and manuscript now use “stream” rather than “creek” throughout, and we report only stable isotope results based on values without lipid correction to avoid propagating uncertainty from that correction.

Thank you for considering our revised manuscript. We look forward to the possibility of sharing this work with the readers of *Ecology*.

Sincerely,



Charlotte A. Ward
on behalf of all co-authors